LIBRARY OF CONGRESS

Organizational Rebrand
Research

Luke Fitzpatrick
March 2026

Mission

The Library of Congress is a Library for YOU.

From its founding the Library of Congress has been a cornerstone of knowledge for the U.S.

It is an institute dedicated to the democracy of knowledge for congress, scholars, and the public.

History

The Library of Congress is a renowned bastion of knowledge, culture and history and an awe-inspiring American achievement. For more than two centuries, we have provided the U.S. Congress and its constituents access to the greatest collection of information and resources ever assembled. As the largest library in the world, with more than 176 million physical items and a growing digital collection, we have the responsibility to continue to collect, preserve and share these treasures with users from coast to coast.

The Library of Congress is the largest library in the world, located in Washington D.C. The Library was first founded in 1800 by John Adams, a founding father of the U.S. Thomas Jefferson was a large proponent of the Library and the link of knowledge and democracy. He even aided in the reconstruction of the Library after the war of 1812. (Donating his personal collection to the library). There is also a deep connection between the Library of Congress and the Presidency as the president is who appoints the Librarians of Congress.

Initially the Library of Congress was located in the US Capitol Building. It wasn't until 1873 that construction began for a new, separate building. It was completed in 1897. This completion also marked the opening of the library to the general public.

Going into the 20th century, under President Theodore Rosevelt, funding for the Library was increased and an aggressive push went across the country to establish strong library services.

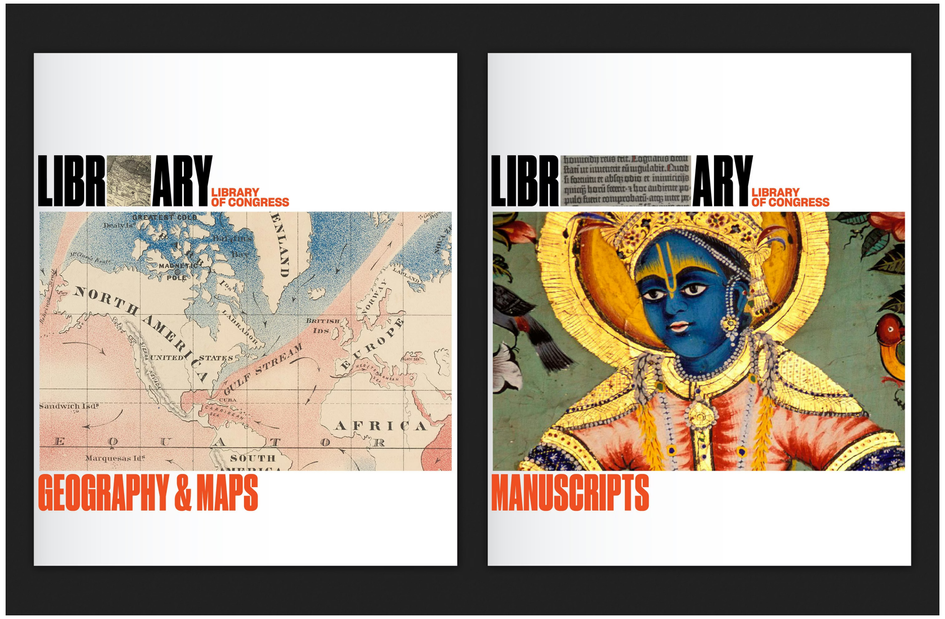
After the two world wars, there was a stronger international role growing for the library. From 1954 to 1971 the library went through tremendous growth in all aspects. Staff, catalog, funding, and more.

The library would begin to adapt to the digital age, beginning in the 1990s. In 2016 Carla Hayden, the first female and African American librarian of congress, was appointed. She played a pivotal role in modernizing the Library and increasing its accessibility. Carla was fired by Trump in 2025. The current Librarian is Robert Newlen.

Current Visual Identity *What Works*

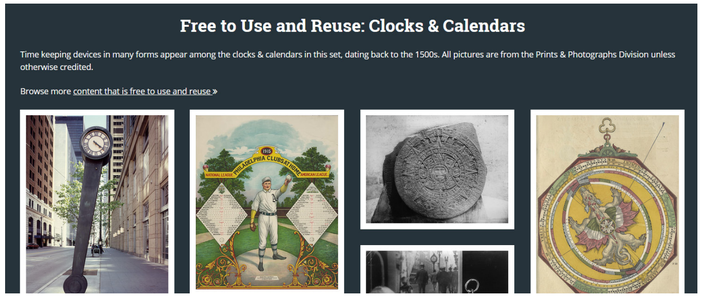
“Casual visitors often fixate on the words ‘of Congress,’ and are unsure whether they are allowed to use the resources here. Emphasizing the word ‘library’ as a word mark helps deliver the message that the Library of Congress and its resources are for everyone.”

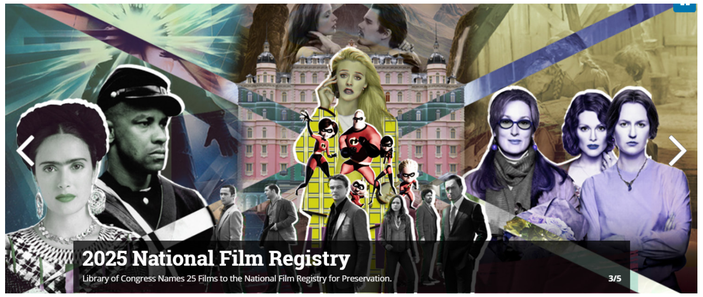
This quote is from the Library’s communications officer. They certainly achieved their goal. The current branding feels inviting, makes me want to explore. I love this ideology and idea in the construction of the current brand.



I love this general style. It’s blue, american, the white bold outlines feel distinct and have that unique flare other graphics had, but still feels scholarly, academic, and formal.

This visual on the homepage is actually so dope. But if we take this unique branding with the styling pictured above there appears to be a disconnect. One is loud, fun, and bold. The mismatch isn’t huge though.





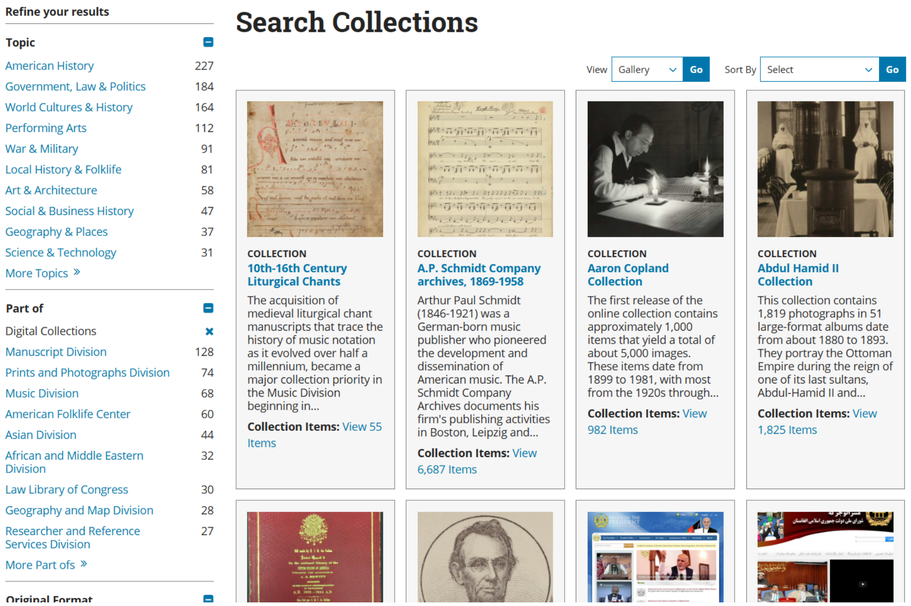
Current Visual Identity *What Doesn't Works*

LIBRARY

I don't think the library of Congress has bad visual branding. It is unique and contemporary. However it is also very bold and loud and does not feel like it properly represents the full prestige that a place with such a storied history. The biggest issue presents itself with why on earth do we have "LIBRARY" twice. It is redundant.

Take a step further back and remove all photography and the logo becomes generic. This logo now becomes something that could be used for any library. Not THE Library of Congress.

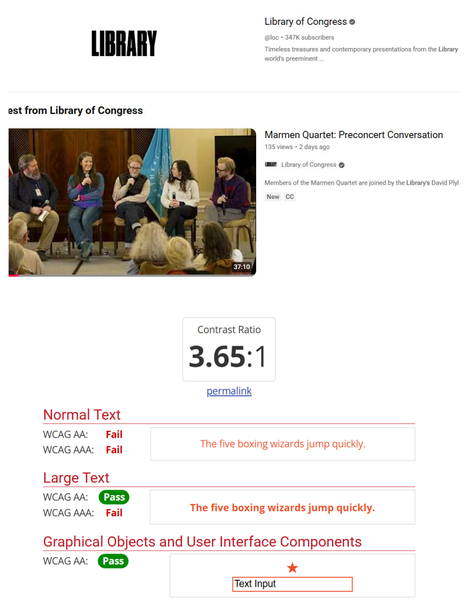
If I were to divorce the words "Library of Congress" from the logo, how would I know that this is for the loc?



Revisiting this style. The font feels a bit childish. The bold san-serrif does not give off prestige. Its reminds me of local library.

Colors are inconsistent and all over the place. Sometimes it's all orange or all blue.

There is little consistency.



Searching their youtube channel there was just the big bold word of Library. look how squished, difficult to read, and boring it appears.

The current color scheme does not meet accessibility standards. This needs to be fixed if we are wanting public accessibility.

Competitor and Peer Landscape

This logo represents the stone lions often depicted in front of a library. It's a unique and identifiable logo. The boldness of the library draws the eye, we are immediately aware that this is a library. Also, the san-serrif font matches the fast paced lifestyle of NYC. The text does feel like it needs to be centered.

I enjoy this one. It is clearly a book. I could not mistake it for a non book related location. However, it is also generic. There is no way I connect this to Boston. The Bold font choice is fine, but it feels a bit cramped.

Harvard library is the oldest library system in the US and the largest academic library in the world. This logo is just the Harvard logo. It has a prestige to it and feels very academic. The font is this old feeling sans-serif font and feels very important. It feels old but matches the history of this library.

I thought it might also be valuable to look at museum logos. I found the Met's logo played well with the letters and how they connect. It had a modern vibe and also feeling formal and dignified. It feels cool!

The way the logo combines the flag and the book feels clever and american. The blue also lends itself to this feeling. The Serif font feels dignified but dated. This logo also feels steril and univiting.

The silhouette of the building's dome is nice. However, as a logo it is too detailed. It also feels just like a generic dome. Without the text I wouldn't know its the library of congress. The text is fine, it feels governmental, official. I don't like the mismatch of the italics.

Audience

The Library of Congress is a place for everyone.

In reality those visiting this library will likely be academically inclined.

The Library's primary function is to fufill research requests for members of Congress.

Key Attributes

1. Inviting

I should feel like I can use the Library of Congress whenever I want. This was stated as a major reason for the rebrand The new logo should first and foremost appeal to everyone.

2. America

This is the nation's library, that is essential to convey. If I can't do this through shape can do so through color.

3. Formality

This may contradict inviting but this is still a historic research institute and belongs to the government. It should feel respectable.

4. Library

People should know this logo belongs to a library.

5. Scale

The Library of Congress is one of the largest libraries in the world. The LOC is a castle of books and should be showcased as such.

Cited

https://qz.com/1369753/us-library-of-congress-unveils-new-logo-designed-by-pentagram-partner-paula-scher

https://www.loc.gov/about/history-of-the-library/

https://www.pentagram.com/work/library-of-congress

https://medium.com/graphic-language/library-of-congress-logo-critique-20846968e2ea

https://www.loc.gov/about/frequently-asked-questions/

LIBRARY OF CONGRESS

Organizational Rebrand
Process Documentation

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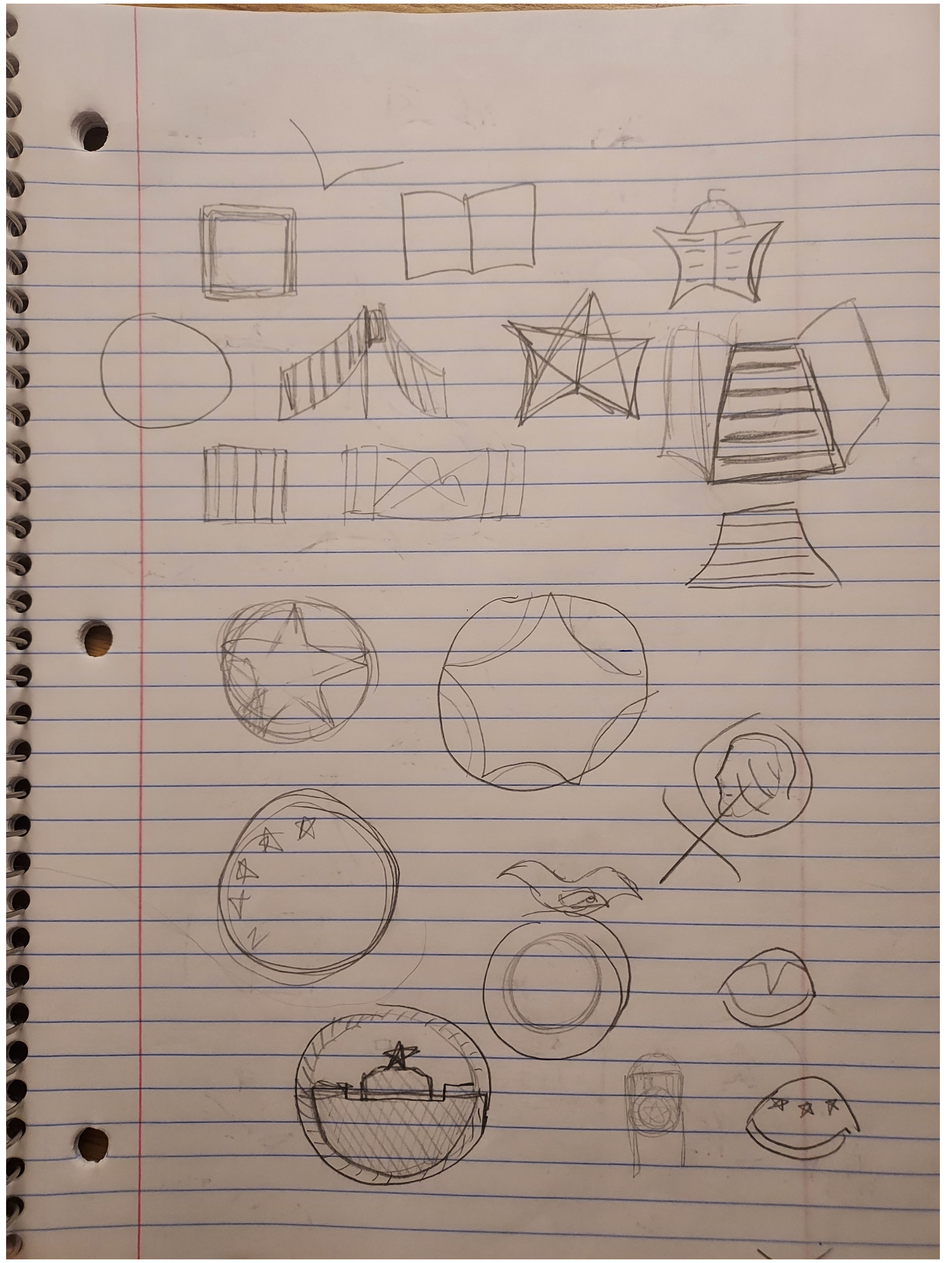
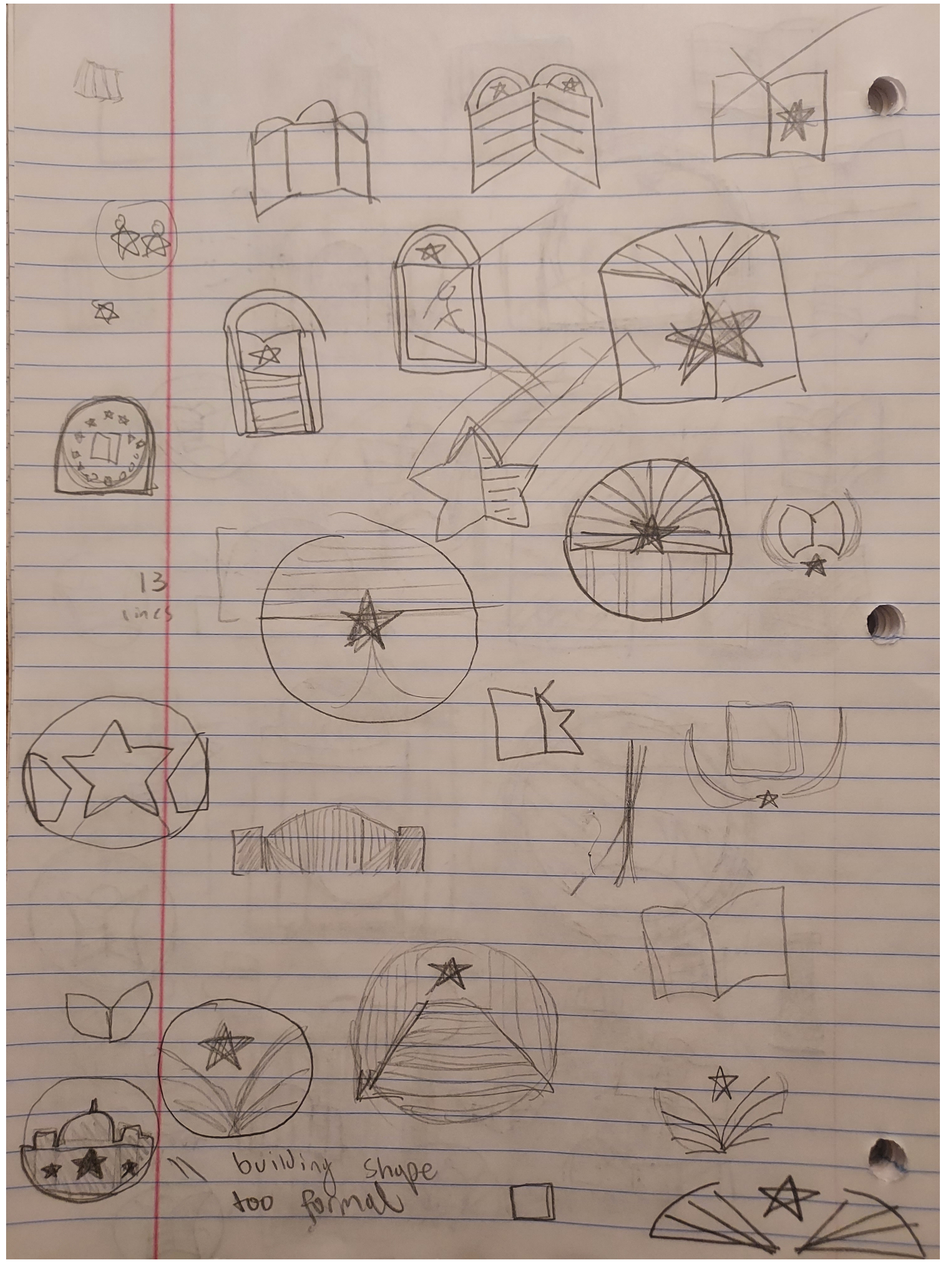
Initial Explorations

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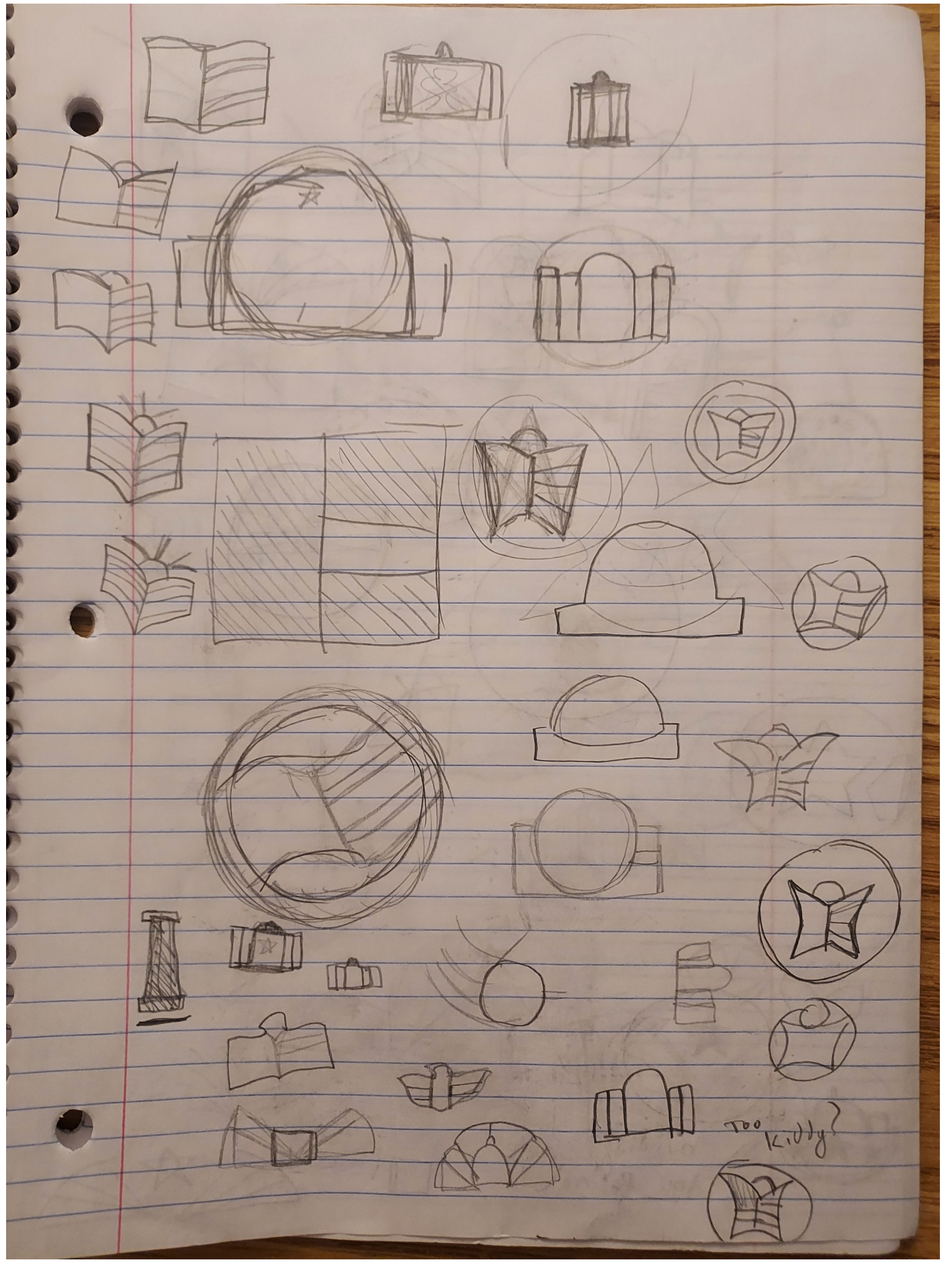
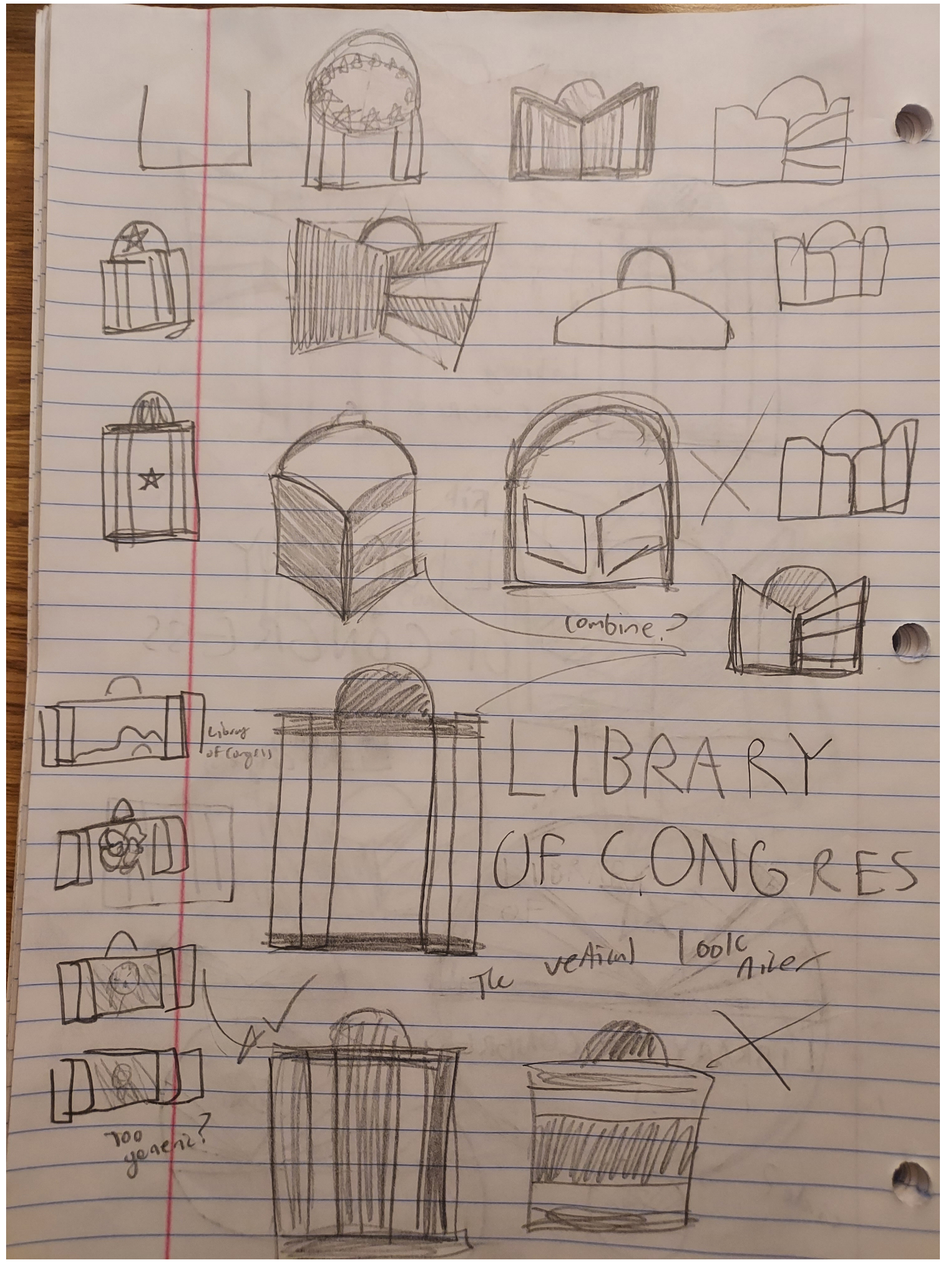

too kiddy?


combine?
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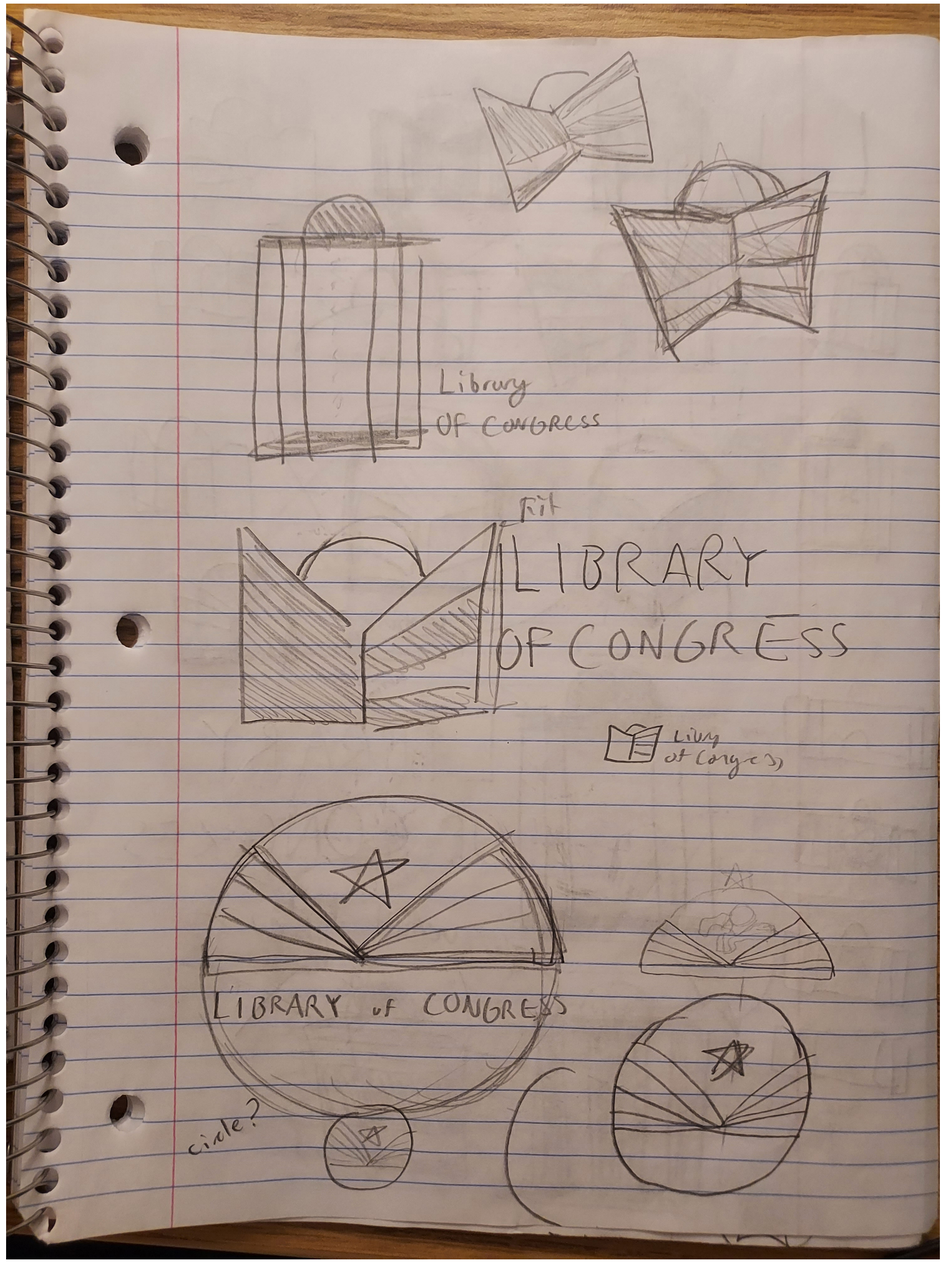
too generic?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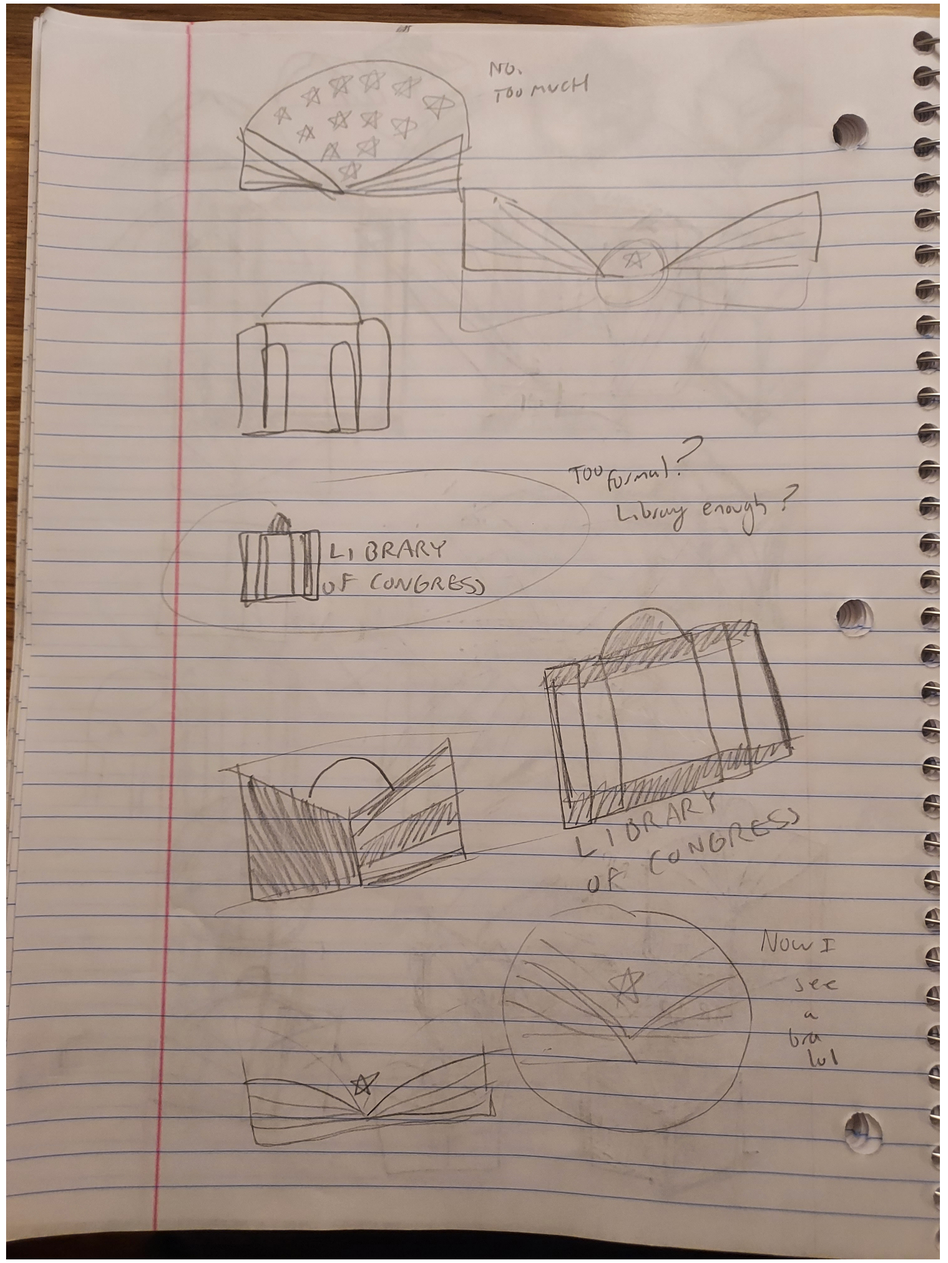
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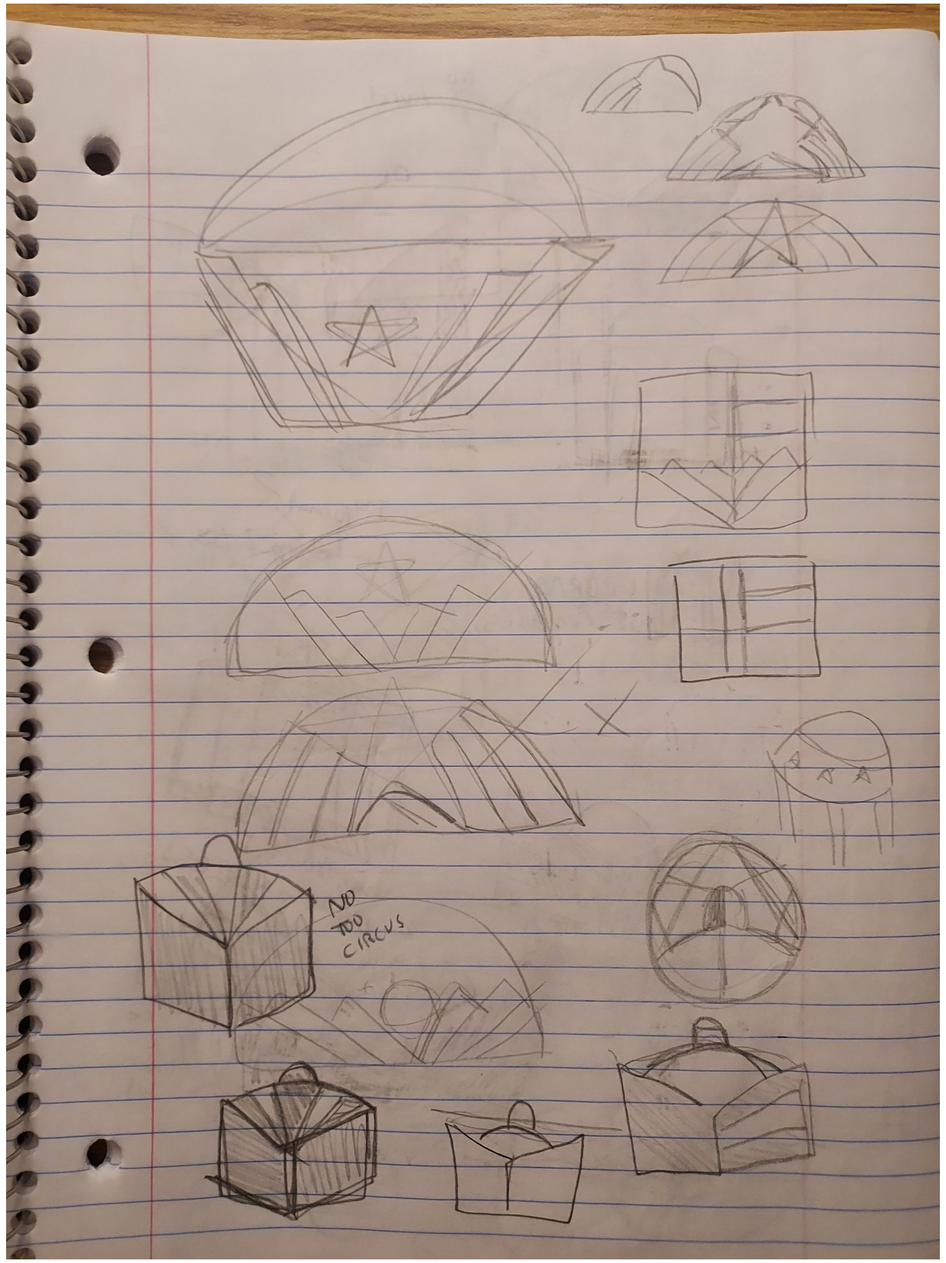
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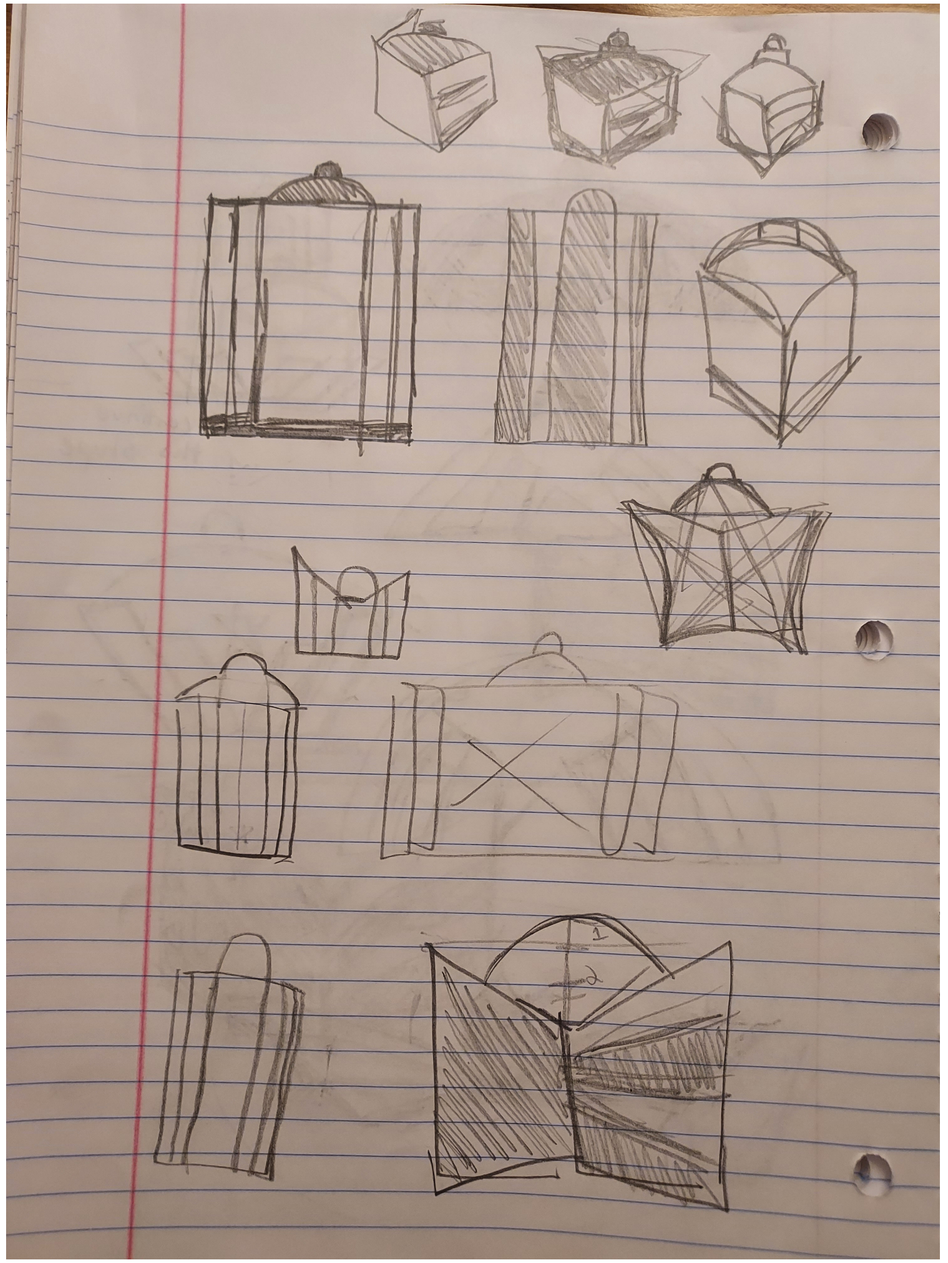

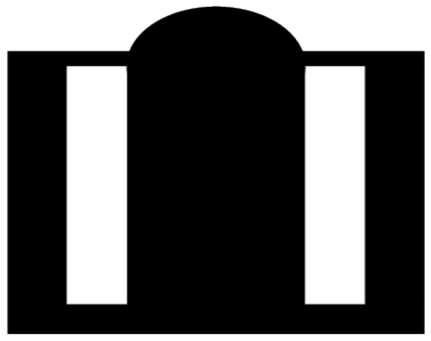

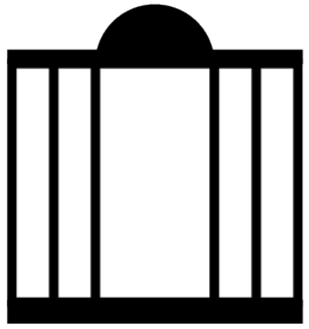

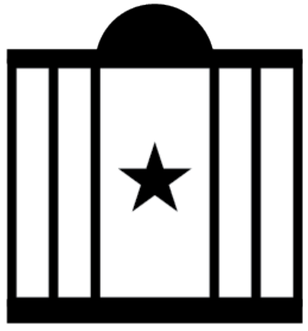

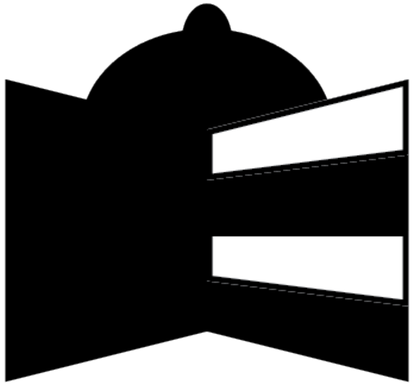

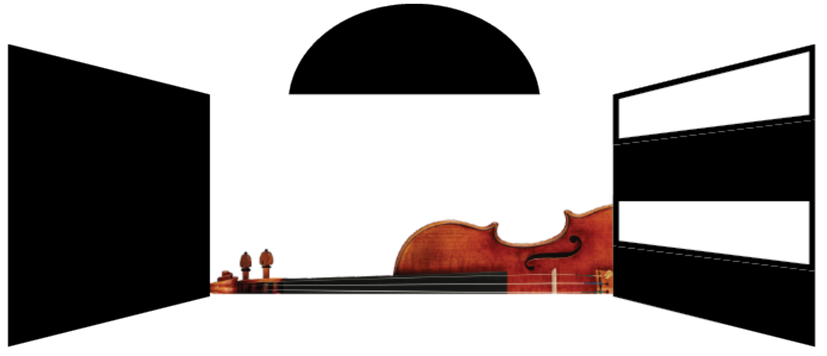

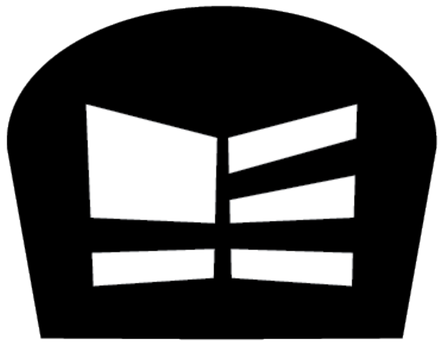

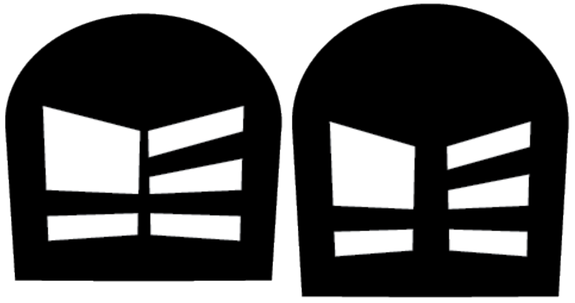

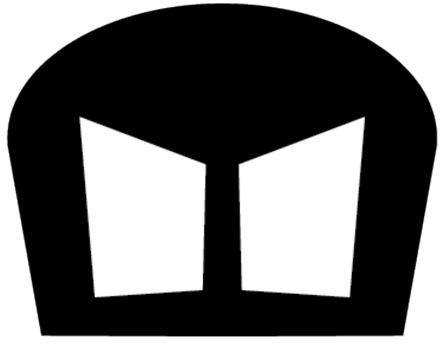

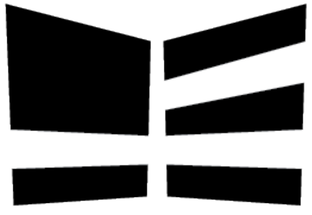

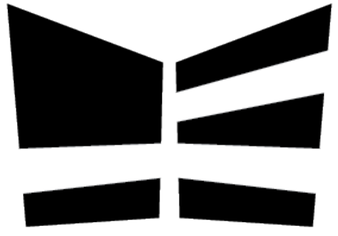

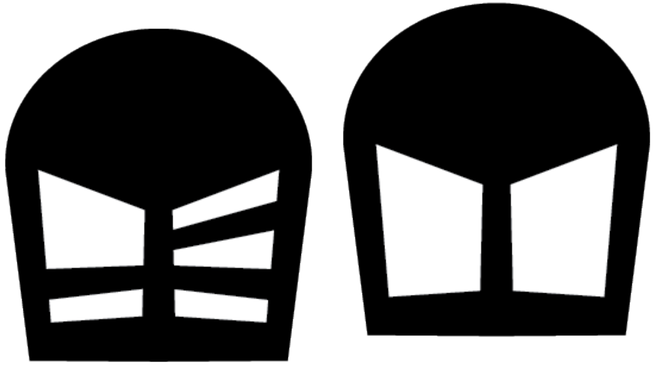

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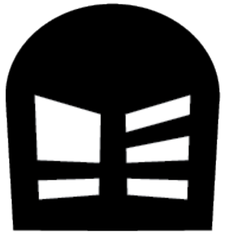

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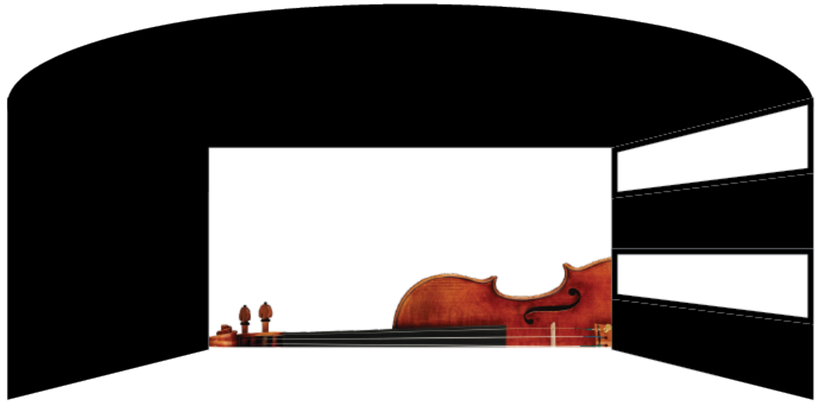

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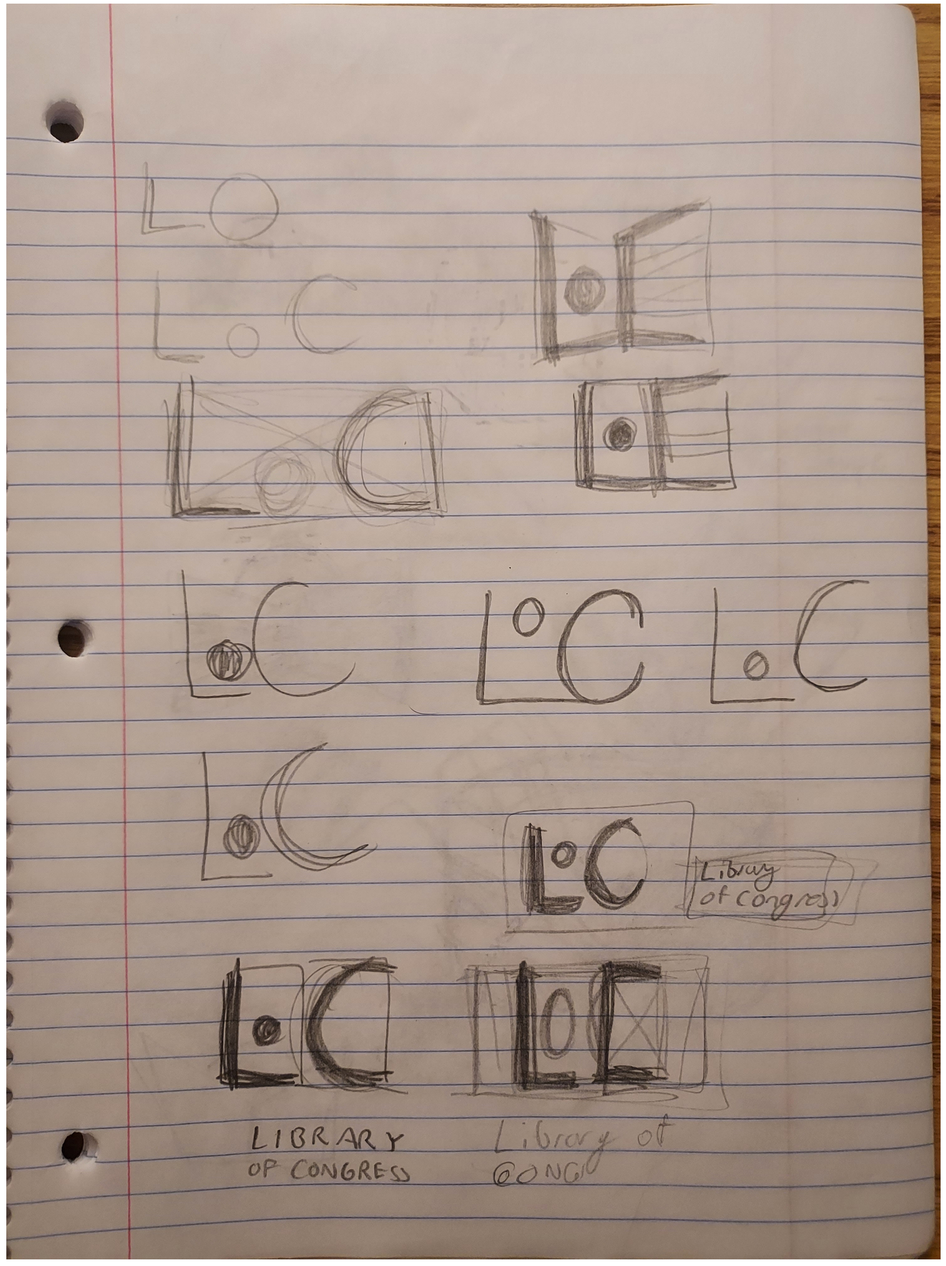
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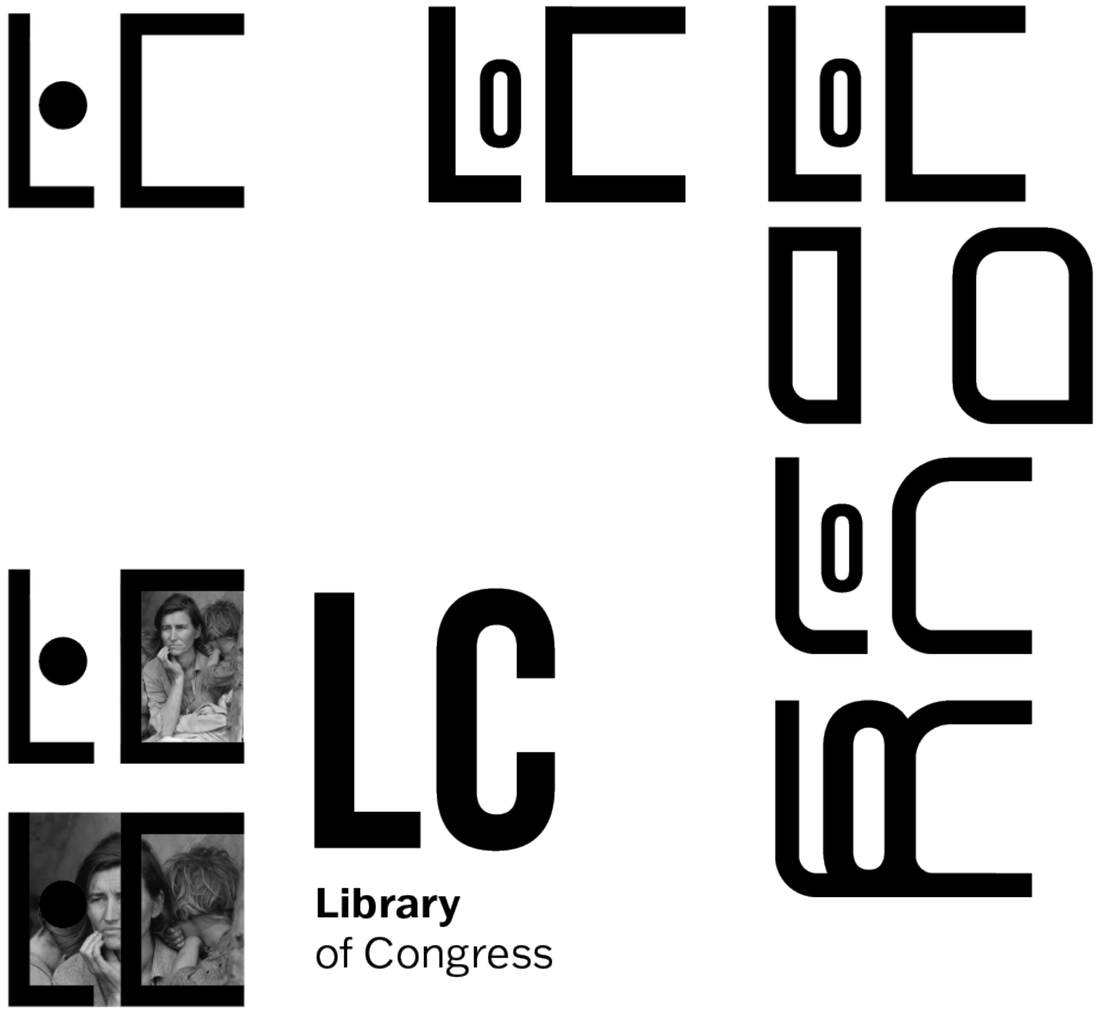
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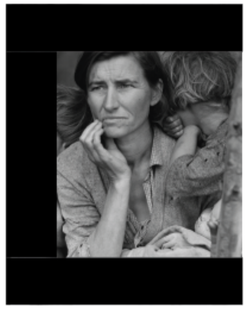

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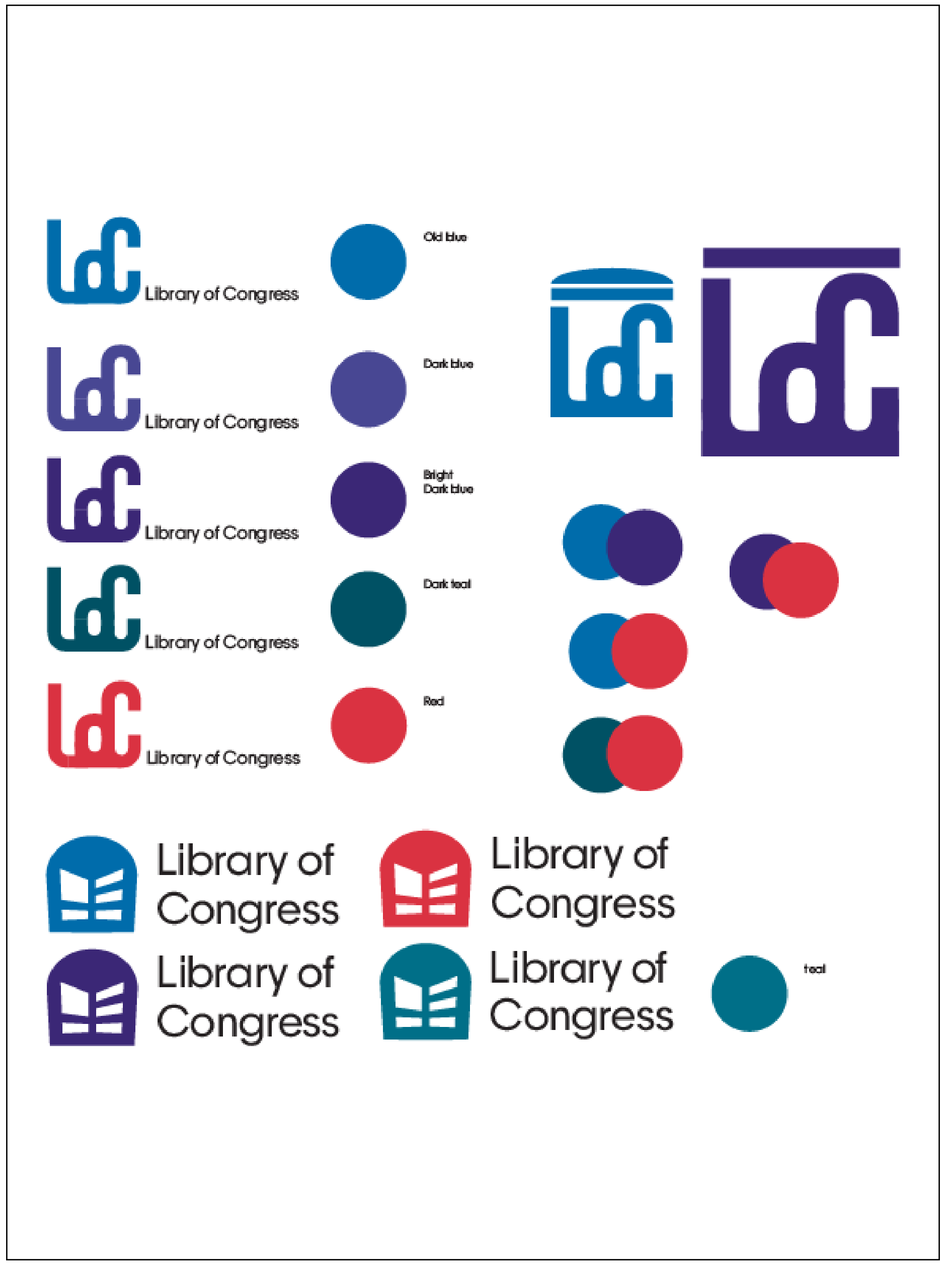
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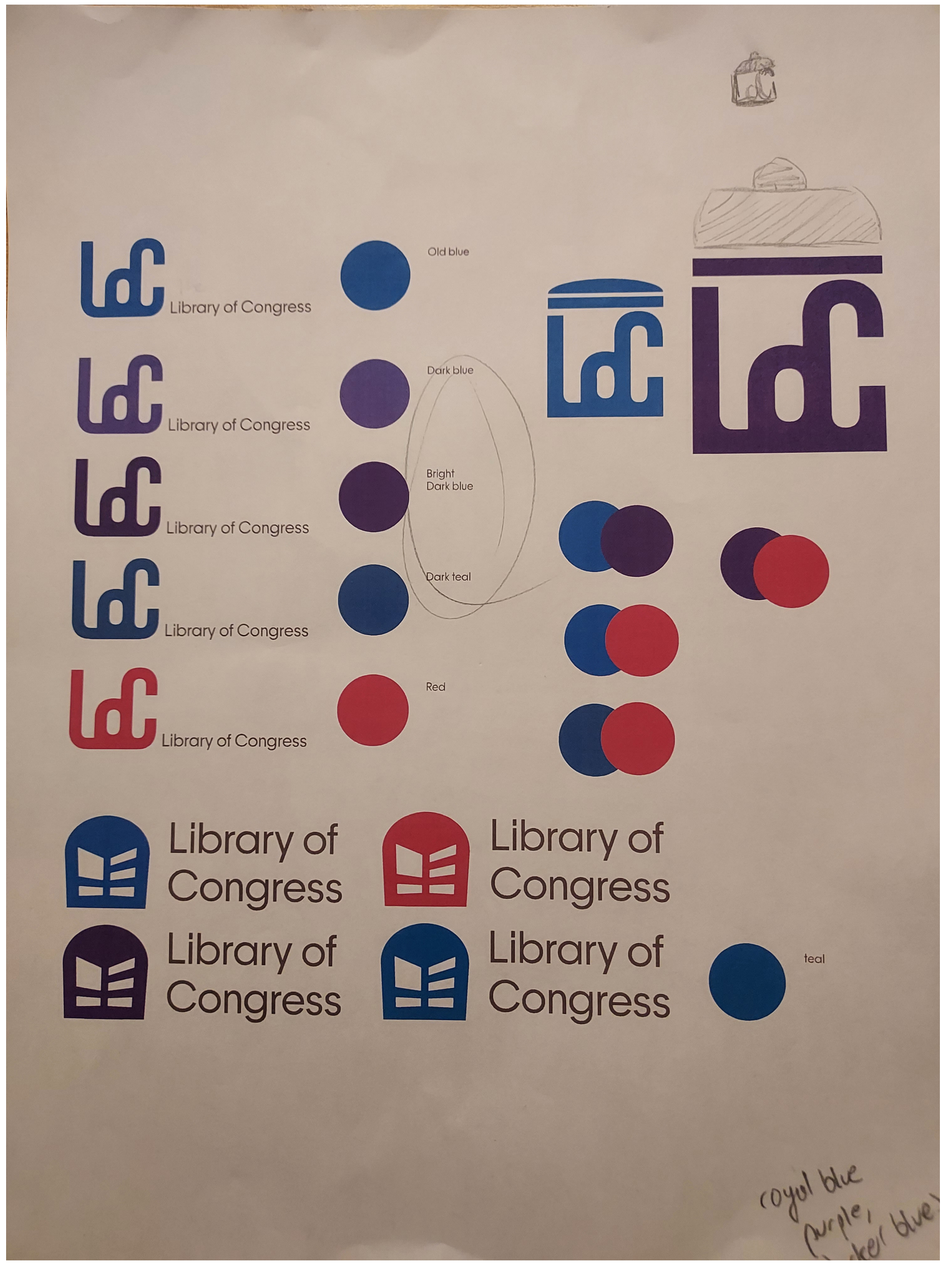
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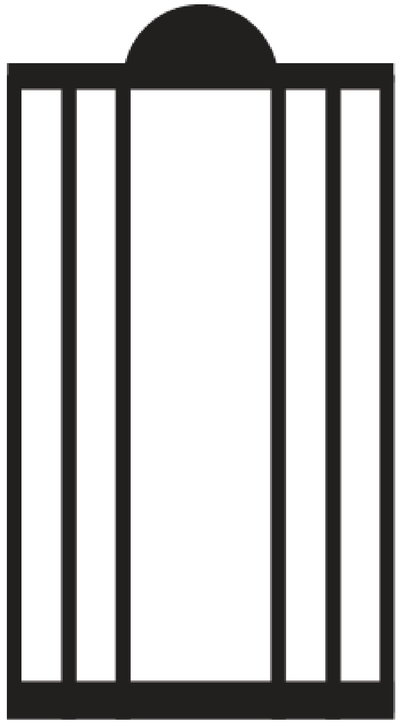
Concept Directions

Direction A

This was my first major idea I enjoyed. Ultimately, I abandoned it as I felt it was too formal and generic. This logo did not convey “Library” at all.”

My main goal with this logo was to have a stylized version of the Library of Congress building. While also having it feel like a bookshelf. I intentionally included room to expand the middle and place images.

The font used was Franklin Gothic, a very American font. However, it lacked a modern feel that I felt necessary to include in the rebrand.



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Direction B

For direction B I took a different approach, I found the previous Library of Congress's branding was well done and clever with the mix of a book and american flag. However, I felt it needed to be simplified down and feel less formal. I simplified the design and straightened out the edges.

I experimented with how many stripes to add. Initially I had 4, but it felt uneven. When I tried 5 stripes instead the design clicked much better. I then tried expanding the stripes to the left to mirror the flag a bit more. This is when the design clicked for me.

I also tried out different ways to frame the logo. Eventually I decided on a basic dome shape, representing the building itself.

For the font I looked into Frama. This was suggested by my twin brother who's a graphic designer. It's similar to Futura with a bit more roundness to it. It felt very modern and clean so I went with it. I felt the roundness of the letters matched well with the dome motif.

Direction C

For direction C I pivoted towards lettermarks. I thought that I could perhaps cleverly combine the L and C to form a book. I sketched out some shapes and played around in Illustrator. Eventually I came up with the design on the left.

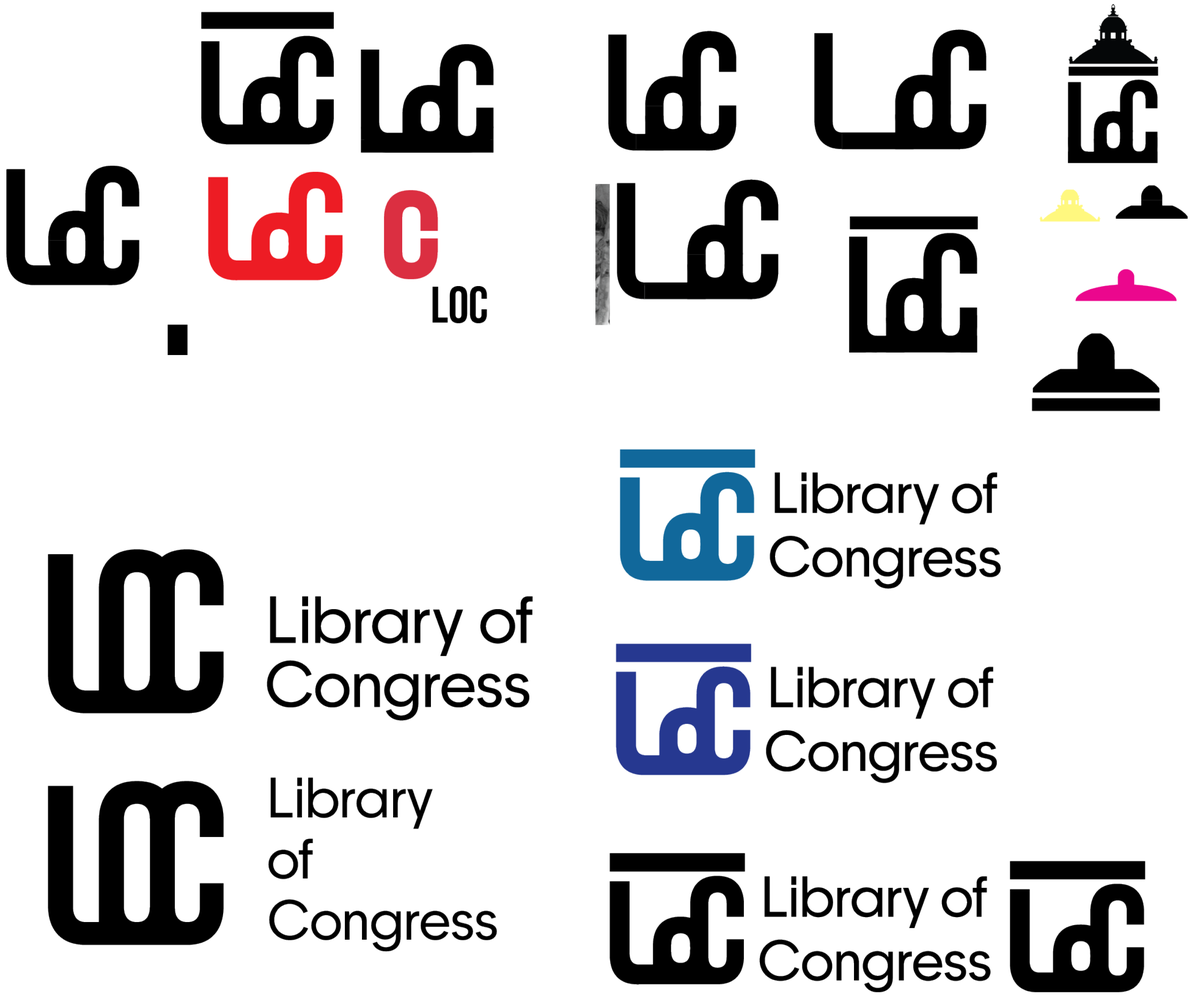
The letterform text was extrapolated from the font Bebas Neue. Bebas Neue was made for a worldwide audience with an intention to be both retro and futuristic. I thought this matched the mission of someplace like the Library of Congress. For the font itself I kept with Frama.

Final Direction

In the end, I went with direction C as I kept returning to it as my favorite. For me this logo clicked the most when I looked at museum logos. It felt modern and in place among them. I thought it brought a feeling of “this place is cool, I should go there.” Which was my biggest goal in the redesign. The library attribute is a bit more subtle but I was going for a bookshelf like shape. This was taken from the current logo.

Direction B was a close second for me. While I enjoyed what I was going with it, the logo also felt plain. It looked more like a flag and less like a book. I also couldn’t get it to sit right in the dome shape.

Refinement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The largest change I made was changing the height of the O. Lowering the O made the design feel a bit less ambiguous. Everyone I showed enjoyed the smaller O more. It also made more sense, as “of” was less important.

As I continued to play with a dome shape I ended up I tried a single line on top. I felt it framed the logo well.

I was very unsure whether to have round corners or sharp ones. I received more positive feedback for the round corners.

I recieved positive feedback on the font I chose. As I was deciding between two different ones this was valuable.

For further refinement I gridded the logo to make sure most the shapes were even.

Feedback and Revisions

In class I received overall positive feedback on my logo. However, I also received multiple critiques that my design was not mature enough to match a government organization.

Other redesigns utilized serif fonts. I tried out different fonts but none of them seemed to click well or match well with the logo I had.

Eventually I decided to capitalize the organization name. This allowed me to keep the font I had chosen earlier while also bringing a more sophisticated feeling to the design that is needed for a place intertwined with the government.

LIBRARY OF CONGRESS

Organizational Rebrand
Styleguide

Luke Fitzpatrick
March 2026

Primary Logo

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Logo Variations

When used in a larger size, the L may be moved back to incorporate images into the logo. These images should extend from the top of the logo to the top of the L to the top of the base of the L and from the right of the L to the left of the C.

If the image has transparency these rules may be broken. They image can never extend past the height or width of the logo.

Lockups

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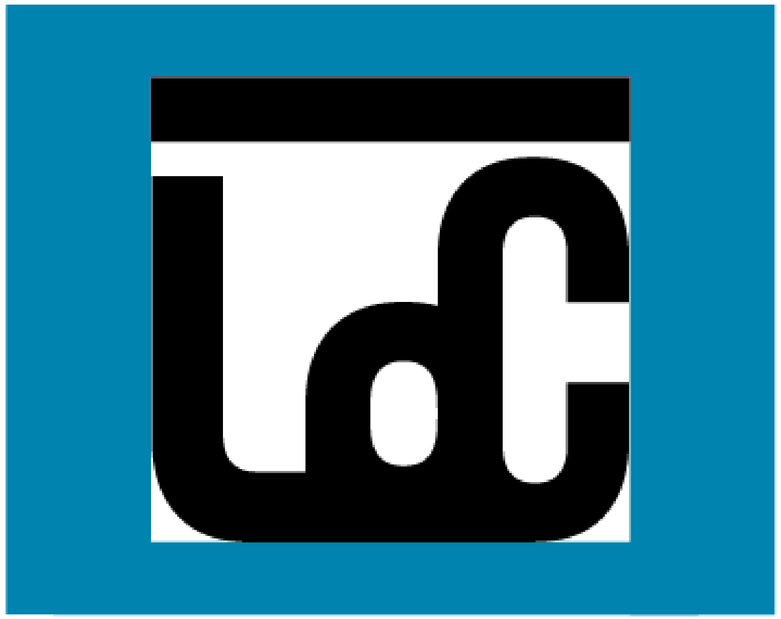
Clear Space



Always maintain at least 0.3X of space left and right of the logo and 0.15X of space on top and bottom of the logo.

Where X is the width of the logo.

Minimum Size

The logo should never have a height smaller than a pixel size of 48 pixels in height on screens. Do not include any text when it would be too small to be legible.

Color Palette

Bright Blue

HEX: #0082ac

RGB: 0, 130, 172

CMYK: 100%, 24%, 0%, 33%

Deep Royal Blue

HEX: #25275e

RGB: 37, 39, 94

CMYK: 61%, 59%, 0%, 63%

The color is composed of both a bright blue and a deep royal blue. Black and white may also be used.

Typography

Use the Frama font family for all materials. Lightweight may be used in conjunction with Regular for large text. Avoid using heavier weights.

Font Family: Frama

A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z 1 2 3 4 5 6 8 9
! ? & a b c d e f g h i j k l m n o p q r s t u v w x y z

Frama Extralight

Frama Extralight Italic

Frama Regular

Frama Regular Italic

Dos and Don’ts

Do

Use images within the logo.

Place the logo above images.

Always use high contrast to ensure accessibility.

Always maintain proper space around the logo.

Don’t

Use images in a non-black logo.

Use an image logo on top of another image.

Use white text on Bright Blue or Bright Blue text on white.

Introduce new colors.

Add any drop shadows or effects to the logo.

Skew or Rotate the logo in any way.

Have text right of the logo extend past its height.

Place the library’s name on the top or left of the logo.

Applications